

Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

LOYALTY BONUS

After the drubbings in three states, the Congress finally gets moving on its 'organisational reshuffle'. The golden rule, though, remains the same: unstinted loyalty to the Gandhi siblings. Take the two new general secretaries: ex-Chhattisgarh CM Bhupesh Baghel (Punjab in-charge) and CWC member Syed Naseer Hussain (handles J&K)—both **Priyanka Gandhi's** favourites. Meanwhile, brother **Rahul Gandhi's** ex-office chief K. Raju now oversees Jharkhand, and longtime confidante Meenakshi Natarajan gets Telangana. But the real showstopper? Harshwardhan Sapkal as Maharashtra Congress president. The ex-MLA is known to be close to Sachin Rao—AICC training head, Congress Sandesh overseer and, crucially, a Rahul inner circle fixture for 15 years. Contrast that with Faisal Patel, son of the late Ahmed Patel—Sonia Gandhi's most trusted aide—who has quit the party, claiming he was getting zero opportunities. No surprises here, Rahul never liked Ahmed Patel.

THE MOTHER LODE

The late AIADMK icon **J. Jayalalithaa's** confiscated assets, transported under high security from Bengaluru to Chennai on February 15, are to be auctioned by the Tamil Nadu government, with the proceeds earmarked for 'rural welfare'. The Supreme Court dismissed the inheritance claims of her niece J. Deepa and nephew J. Deepak.



For DMK chief minister M.K. Stalin, liquidating the land hold holdings, all 1,526.2 acres of it, should be straightforward. The other assets—nearly 28 kg of gold, including a diamond-and-ruby-studded crown and an engraved sword, as well as 1,116 kg of silver artefacts—may require a different approach, though, given the AIADMK's earlier commitment to converting her Poes Garden residence into a museum. After all, Stalin himself has established both a museum and a Rs 39 crore memorial for his late father, ex-CM M. Karunanidhi.

Cash Squeeze

BJP leader and Maharashtra ports and fisheries minister **Nitesh Rane** has stirred up a firestorm again, declaring that villages under Opposition-led panchayats can kiss development funds goodbye. His message? If you want the cash, switch teams and join the BJP. Call it political tough love or just old-fashioned muscle-flexing, it's all about pay-to-play politics now. Democracy may be by the people, but in Rane's playbook, development is strictly for the party.



ANI

Family Plots

In Bihar, the RJD first family is back with another vintage dose of drama. With polls just months away, **Subhash Yadav**—once a trusted aide to sister and ex-CM Rabri Devi—has suddenly found a conscience and decided to blow the whistle on the "lawlessness" of the Lalu-Rabri era. His explosive claim? "Kidnapping cases used to be handled from the CM's house." But the plot thickens.



The estranged Subhash is reportedly angling for his son to get a ticket from Chirag Paswan's LJP. Enter elder brother and ex-MP Sadhu Yadav, who isn't having any of it, calling the allegations "nonsense". Expect more such sizzlers from Bihar's political theatre as the polls near.

LOVE WITHOUT FEAR

This V-Day, the IT cell of the Trinamool Congress's Jalpaiguri unit launched a **Couples Protection Force** to save the young 'uns from the attentions of the moral policing brigade. Think Romeo and Juliet, but with party flags and a rescue squad in the background. And this is just the beginning. By next year, 'love commandos' will be active across Bengal, ensuring no romance is nipped in the bud by fringe Hindutva outfits like the Bajrang Dal, says Debangshu Bhattacharya, the TMC's IT cell chief.



Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Amarnath K. Menon, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Jumana Shah and Dhaval S. Kulkarni